



ACCELERATED EXPERIENCES, LLC

Detailed Specification

The drafted website – what was found, what is built, how it is met

SUBMITTED TO

Montana Legal Services Association

COMPANION TO

The proposal, and the drafted site delivered as a short film (The Montana Tape)

READ FROM

mtlsa.org and montanalawhelp.org - read September 2, verified again September 10, 2026

DUE

September 14, 2026 · 5:00 PM MST

PREPARED BY

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Technical companion. The narrative proposal is a separate document; the two are meant to be read together.

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SECTION 1

What this document is

This is the build specification behind the drafted site. It exists because a rebrand proposal that shows only a logo leaves the hardest questions - information architecture, migration, accessibility, Spanish, safety - to be discovered after the contract is signed. The draft was built first so those questions are answered here, in writing, before award.

Everything about MLSA in this document was read from mtlsa.org and montanalawhelp.org on September 2, 2026 and checked again on September 4. Where something is proposed rather than observed, it says so.

Two properties, not one.

mtlsa.org runs on WordPress and explains the organization. montanalawhelp.org runs on Drupal, holds the forms and guides, carries the Spanish path, and owns the strongest line either property has - "Justice Lives Here." Any rebrand that treats this as a single website will break the half it did not look at. You have two websites, two names, and one Montanan trying to find help.

Findings from the live properties

The accessibility overlay.

mtlsa.org runs an accessibility overlay - the widget at the bottom-left of every page. Its published statement describes an application that runs in the background, a menu of disability profiles, and an Alt+1 screen-reader prompt, and it claims adherence to WCAG 2.1 Level AA on that basis.

Why this is a risk and not a feature.

Screen readers read your HTML. They cannot read a script layered on top, and a script cannot repair barriers in code it does not change. The record is specific: in April 2025 the FTC fined one overlay vendor \$1 million over claims that its automated product could make a website WCAG-compliant, and barred it from repeating them. Of the 4,000-plus ADA digital accessibility suits filed in 2024, roughly a quarter cited widgets and overlays as barriers rather than remedies. For a legal aid organization, a published AA claim resting on an overlay is exposure - the kind a plaintiff's firm looks for first.

Recommendation: remove the overlay. The accessibility belongs in the markup itself. Publish a statement that names the evaluation date, the tools used, and the known exceptions. The drafted site does exactly this (Section 4).

Quick exit is inconsistent across the two properties - verified by pressing both.

mtlsa.org's EXIT SITE control sends the person to google.com. montanalawhelp.org's Quick Exit opens weather.com in a new tab and leaves google.com in the original. The label, the placement and the destination all differ. MLSA takes domestic violence matters as a priority category even during reduced staffing. For someone being watched at home, that inconsistency is the whole product. It is a safety defect, and it is fixed in the draft with one control.

The capacity notice lives in two different banners.

Both properties carry a reduced-staffing notice. Only mtlsa.org states the triage rules - voicemails returned for existing clients, domestic violence matters, and public-housing or Section 8 evictions, with normal staffing resuming October 5. Someone who lands on the forms site and applies never sees it.

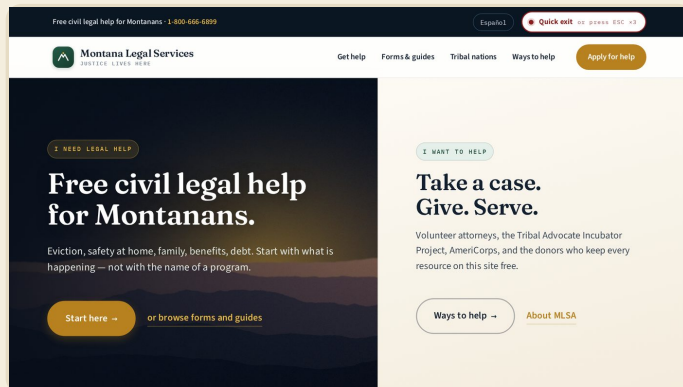
An interstitial on the forms site. montanalawhelp.org opens with a modal asking "Are you an attorney?" and a donate button before the page can be read. A person in crisis meets a fundraising question first. The draft has no interstitials on any client-facing path.

Deep content sits behind org-chart navigation. The Tribal Advocate Incubator Project and the Land Acknowledgement are both published and both several levels down. The draft gives tribal justice a top-level door, which is a design decision that says something either way.

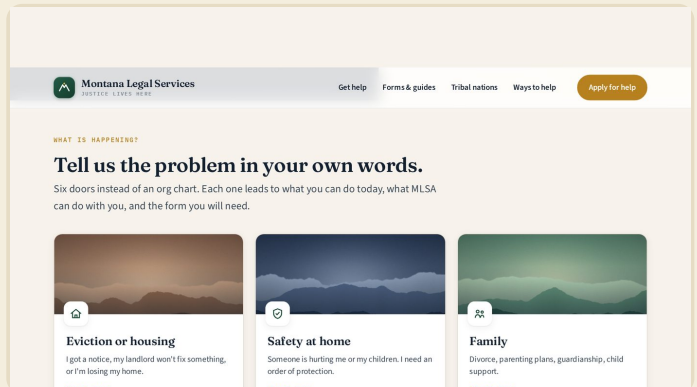
SECTION 2

The draft as built

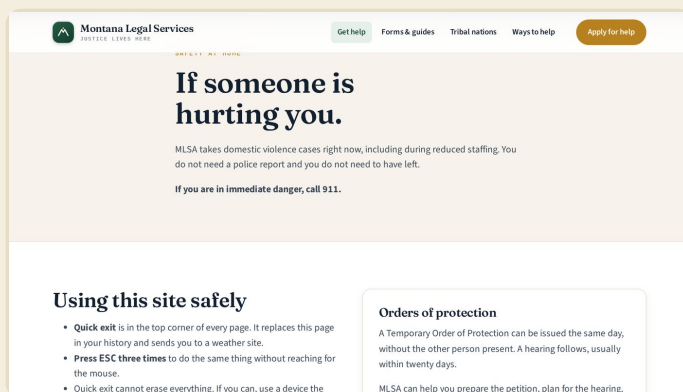
Nine pages, built as real HTML with real fonts, and filmed for The Montana Tape. It is a draft of structure and behavior, not the final identity - the identity comes out of the process in Section 3 with your staff, board and funders in the room. Every frame below is from the draft itself.



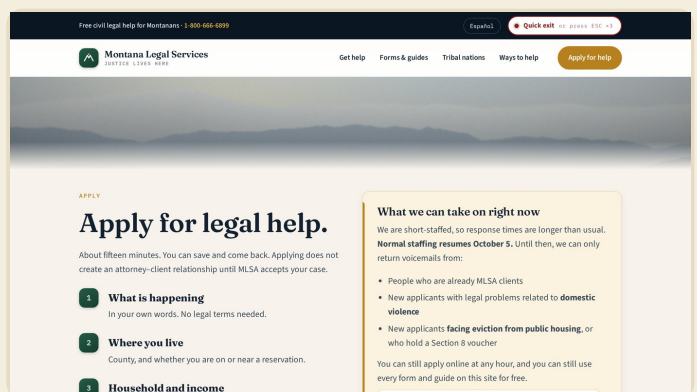
THE HOMEPAGE - TWO DOORS



SIX PLAIN-LANGUAGE WAYS IN



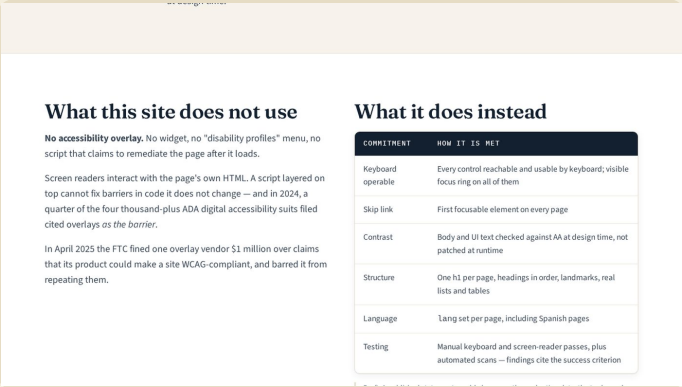
SAFETY AT HOME - QUICK EXIT



APPLY - CAPACITY NOTICE BESIDE THE BUTTON



ESPAÑOL - A REAL PATH, NOT A PLUGIN



ACCESSIBILITY - THE COMMITMENTS TABLE

Design system in the draft

ELEMENT	WHAT THE DRAFT USES	STATUS
Typefaces	Fraunces for headings, Source Sans 3 for reading text, IBM Plex Mono for labels and phone numbers. All open-license, self-hosted, no font fees.	Proposed - revisited in identity
Color	Deep ink (#141c2e) on warm paper (#f7f3ea), one forest green for action, one signal red reserved for the quick-exit control only. Every text and background pairing checked at AA.	Proposed
Mark	A mountain-and-ridgeline mark holds the place where the identity will go. It is a placeholder so the draft could be filmed; it is not the recommended logo.	Placeholder
Imagery	Ridgeline landscapes generated for the draft so no stock photograph stands in for Montana. Replaced by real photography under the imagery guidelines in Section 3.	Placeholder
Voice	Plain language on every client-facing page. Second person, short sentences, no program names in navigation. Reviewed against the standard in Section 3.	Proposed

Proposed information architecture

The homepage asks one question - who are you, and what is happening - and every audience reaches what it needs in two clicks. Six doors instead of an org chart.

DOOR	CONTAINS
Get help /get-help	Six plain-language entries: Eviction or housing, Safety at home, Family, Money and debt, Benefits, Tribal courts. Each leads to what you can do today, what MLSA can do with you, and the form you need.
Forms and guides /forms	The migrated MontanaLawHelp.org library, by topic. Free, no account, no application.

DOOR	CONTAINS
Tribal nations /tribal	Tribal court help, ICWA, the Tribal Advocate Incubator Project, Land Acknowledgement.
Ways to help /help-out	Pro Bono Volunteer Attorney Program, Justice for Montanans AmeriCorps, donate.
Apply /apply	Intake, with the capacity notice and the safe-contact question on the same screen.
About /about	Mission, our work, by the numbers, 60th anniversary, staff and board.
Español /es	A first-class path reachable from the top bar of every page, not a footer link.

Components specified in the draft

COMPONENT	BEHAVIOR
Quick exit	In the top bar of every page of both properties, identical label and destination. Replaces the current entry in history, then opens a neutral site. Pressing Esc three times does the same thing without reaching for the mouse. The safety page explains its limits honestly - it cannot erase everything.
Two doors	Crisis on the left, contribute on the right. A person in crisis and a donor want opposite things at opposite speeds, and one homepage serving both usually serves the donor, because the donor is the one in the room when it gets approved.
Six doors	Plain words, each with its own image and icon so the grid is scannable at a glance and on a small screen. Nobody should need a program name to find help.
Capacity notice	A component, not a banner - rendered on the homepage, the get-help page and the apply page from one source. Capacity is a fact. Saying it plainly costs nothing and saves the worst part.
Safe-contact question	Asked at the start of the application: is it safe to call, to leave a voicemail, to send mail here.
Language toggle	Top bar, every page, with lang set correctly on the document.
Trust row	LSC funding, the conformance target, Español, and "no accessibility overlay" - stated plainly.

SECTION 3

The identity work – how it runs

You are buying identity work first. The website is where it lands. Four stages, in the order the proposal's timeline sets out, each ending in something you can hold.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS	WHAT YOU RECEIVE
1 • Discovery Oct 26 - Dec 2026	Stakeholder interviews - staff, board, funders, and the people you serve. Audit of both properties and all printed material. Competitive read of legal aid identities across the region.	Discovery report; audience definitions; brand audit
2 • Renaming analysis Dec 2026 - Jan 2027	Evidence, not preference: search demand for each name, referral pathways through courts, self-help centers and partners, what is printed on handouts, what people actually type. It must be allowed to conclude keep both.	Written recommendation with the evidence and the reasoning
3 • Identity and messaging Jan - Mar 2027	Three distinct concepts presented for review - not one direction with two decoys. Refinement to one. Messaging house written in parallel so the words and the mark are decided together.	Logo suite; palette; typography; usage guidelines; imagery guidelines; brand style guide; PowerPoint template; business card; letterhead banner; messaging house; plain-language standard; transition messaging
4 • Site, launch, training Mar - Jun 2027	The draft rebuilt to the identity, migration with redirects, search, Spanish, accessibility audit, training, launch.	The live site; the audit; the editor training; the rollout plan

Every logo deliverable is supplied as SVG, EPS, PNG and PDF, in full color, one color and reversed, in horizontal and stacked lockups. The style guide gathers all of it into one document your staff can actually use, and the website's design tokens are exported from it so the site and the print never drift apart.

It must be able to conclude: keep both.
If a vendor's renaming process cannot produce that outcome, it is not an analysis - it is a rename with extra steps. Mine can, and if the evidence points to keeping both names, that is what you will get, with the reasoning written down.

Accessibility – how AA is actually met

COMMITMENT	IMPLEMENTATION
Keyboard operable	Every control reachable and usable by keyboard; visible focus ring on all of them, never suppressed
Skip link	First focusable element on every page, visible on focus
Structure	One h1 per page, headings in order, landmark regions, real lists and tables
Contrast	Checked against AA at design time, not patched at runtime
Language	lang per document, including Spanish pages and inline Spanish
Motion	No autoplaying carousels; the current homepage rotates hero slides and testimonial panes
Testing	Manual keyboard and screen-reader passes (NVDA, VoiceOver) over real tasks, plus automated scans - every finding cites its success criterion
Statement	Names the evaluation date, tools, and known exceptions. No disability-profile menu. No overlay.

The rule: no citation, no finding.

An item that cannot name the WCAG success criterion it violates is an opinion, and you should not pay to remediate opinions. The corollary is that I will also tell you which findings not to fix yet - a report that flags everything at equal weight is a report that gets shelved.

SECTION 5

Build, migration and Spanish

AREA	SPECIFICATION
Platform	CMS chosen on fit, not habit. You are open on platform, and the honest answer depends on who edits the site and how often. Decided in Discovery with the editors in the room; the design is built so the choice does not change the pages.
Licensing	No per-seat licensing. Your cost never climbs when you add an editor. Open-license typefaces, self-hosted.
Migration	The forms library is the asset. MontanaLawHelp.org holds years of curated forms and guides. URLs preserved, redirects in place - links to those guides are printed on court handouts, self-help center flyers, and in partner referral lists. They keep working.
Search	One search across pages, forms and guides, tuned so plain-language searches such as "landlord won't fix" find the eviction door and the right form.

AREA	SPECIFICATION
Spanish	A real content field - written, reviewed, and reachable from every page. Machine translation reads like machine translation to the person who needs it, and legal aid serves the people least able to absorb a bad guess about their rights.
Integrations	Intake, donation and volunteer forms connected to the systems you already run; nothing replaced that does not need replacing.
Continuity	Analytics and search-ranking continuity checked after cutover, so a drop is caught in week one rather than quarter two.
Performance	Pages built to load on a rural connection and an old phone: no client-side framework required to read a page, images sized to the screen, fonts subset.
Ownership	You own the code, the content, the design files and the accounts. Documentation and editor training are deliverables, not extras.

Testing and acceptance

- Browser testing across current Chrome, Safari, Firefox and Edge, desktop and mobile, plus a deliberate low-bandwidth pass.
- Accessibility audit before launch under the rule in Section 4; findings fixed or listed as known exceptions in the published statement.
- Content acceptance page by page, with MLSA staff signing off the client-facing text against the plain-language standard.
- Launch checklist: redirects verified, search verified, forms verified end to end, Spanish path verified, quick exit verified on every page of both properties.

Stated plainly, because you will check. The draft filmed in The Montana Tape is the draft described here. Nothing in this specification is promised that is not already standing in it or named as a stage of the work above.



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